Lesson Plan: How to Write a Thesis Statement

Students will learn how to write a thesis statement!

STUDENTS WILL…

- See how pre-writing about specific points leads to more complex, sophisticated ideas
- Understand what a thesis statement is
- Understand how observation and analysis create strong, complex thesis statements
- Write their own observation and analysis on their topic
- Use their observation and analysis to write a thesis statement

MATERIALS NEEDED

Slide deck · Student laptops/chromebooks and access to yawp.school

Optional Opening: Review

1. Review assessment questions about critical essays. Ask the class first, then reveal the answer on the next slide.

   SLIDES 2–7

Opening Activity: Observation and Analysis

1. Show students the photograph on the board and ask them to observe it/analyze it. Ask, “What’s happening in this picture?” When students offer theories, ask them, “What do you see in the picture that makes you say that?” Stand next to the slide and point out details that the students might be seeing.

   SLIDES 8–9

2. (The purpose of this exercise is to teach students the relationship between observation and analysis so that they understand how to use both in their thesis statements.)

The Lesson

1. Depending on where you are as a class, students may need to pre-write more on their specific “diamonds” to get more ideas out. In other cases, students may have already pre-written to the point of finding their specific focus (the goal of pre-writing) and may be ready to get into thesis statements. Use your judgment here: based on what you see on student docs, if they have identified specific areas of focus, then they’re ready to get into thesis statements; if they could benefit from more pre-writing, then give them some time at the start to get more ideas out.

2. Using the **Critical Essay Form** handout/slide, do a quick review of the importance/role of the thesis statement.

   SLIDES 10–12

3. Using the slide deck, talk about how all of the students' pre-writing up to this point has allowed them to get out ideas and find a focus for their essay. Now, they're ready to write their thesis statement.

   SLIDE 13

   a. **Define thesis statement** (keep in mind that many students have never written an essay like this before, so a thesis statement might be a very abstract concept to them. Don't dwell on this.)

      SLIDES 14–15

   b. Go through the slides that define a thesis statement: have students read parts of the slides, if it helps keep them engaged.

      SLIDE 16

   c. Go through slides on **"observation"**: feel free to ask students if they can define this word, and see if you can get students participating. Show them the examples of observation statements.

      SLIDES 17–22

   d. Go through the slides on **analysis**: call on students to read some of these.

      SLIDES 23–25

   e. Very carefully and clearly review the slides on **Observation + Analysis.** Let students see and understand how the analysis is connected to the observation.

      SLIDES 26–28

   f. Then, review the slides on **Combining the Observation and Analysis to Form a Thesis.**

      SLIDES 31–36

4. **Writing Activity:**

   SLIDES 29–30

   a. Students should log onto yawp.school. Make sure they are on the **"Thesis Statement"** module (noted at the top of the Tutor).

   b. If students completed the pre-writing process in the last class, they should have a specific topic at the end of their pre-write. This specific topic will be their starting point today.

   c. Students should follow the instructions and go through the Thesis process.

   d. As students begin this process, go around the room and check in with as many students as possible. Help them to identify/compose their observation-analysis.

   e. NOTE: Even for seasoned writers, developing a thesis statement takes time and effort. Help students as much as they need it.

   f. As students draft their thesis statements, they can ask the Tutor for feedback. Note: sometimes the Tutor may make a suggestion around word choice that removes or sterilizes the student's voice. Be on the lookout for this, and help the students word/shape their thesis statements in effective ways.

5. **Optional: Avoid the verb "to be."** The second half of the deck shows how cutting "to be" clears clutter out of a thesis and makes room for stronger verbs. Use it for your own understanding (it helps with revising thesis statements after class), or share it if your students' writing is ready for it. You can also end the lesson before it.

   SLIDES 37–45

Following Class

1. Check each student's document to ensure that they have a strong, working thesis statement. Give them a positive comment about the work they've done.
2. Revise any thesis statements that are wordy or syntactically incorrect. This kind of intervention is sometimes necessary. It's best to keep their original and then show them the "Revised Thesis" below so that they can see the differences and understand the improvements made.
3. The goal here is that at the start of the next class, every student who was present for the Thesis Lesson has a working thesis statement. Unless a student was absent today, you shouldn't move on to the Introduction Paragraph lesson until all students have their thesis statements.

Adapted from Brian Connell's lesson plan for the YAWP! Writing Program, with slide numbers for the new deck. The review quiz and the optional "to be" section are added; Brian's plan didn't mention them.